

Topic 6.2 - The stages of a teaching career

A real classroom situation

Three teachers sit in the same in-service session on questioning technique.

Sana is on practicum. She has taught nine lessons in her life and is still working out how to stand. The session's advice about wait time is interesting and she has no room in which to try it, because she is concentrating on getting through the material without losing the class.

Imran is in his second month of employment. He knows about wait time. He also has a Class 8 that talks over him, and everything he has been given assumes a room that listens.

Mrs Aslam has taught for nineteen years. She has heard this session, or something close to it, five times. She could deliver it. What she has not had in nineteen years is one person watching her teach and telling her something true.

The same session. Three entirely different needs, one of which it meets.

Explanation

The preservice stage

The preservice stage covers initial teacher education up to qualification: your own position now.

What changes at its end is responsibility. A trainee observes, assists, and teaches under supervision with someone else accountable for the class. A qualified teacher is accountable.

The characteristic difficulty is that almost everything is new at once, so attention is consumed by mechanics: where to stand, how to start, how to get

thirty books collected without losing ten minutes. Sana is not failing to apply wait time; she has no spare attention with which to apply it.

What this stage needs is structured practice with feedback, in a real classroom, on a small number of things at a time. Not more content. Day (1999), writing about teacher development across a working life, situates initial preparation as the beginning of a long process rather than as a loading of everything required.

What is usually offered instead is a heavy content curriculum and a short practicum, which is the pattern in most systems including this one. The practical response is to use your practicum deliberately: the transfer tasks in this course exist because a practicum used for observation alone teaches much less than one used for structured trials.

The new teacher stage

The new teacher stage covers roughly the first three to five years.

What changes at its beginning is that you are alone with a class and responsible for what happens in it. This transition is abrupt in teaching in a way it is not in most professions: a new doctor is supervised for years; a new teacher frequently has the same load as a colleague of twenty years' standing from the first week.

The characteristic difficulty is survival. The demands are immediate and continuous, and the teacher has not yet built the automatic routines that later make room for thought. Imran knows about wait time, and his problem is not knowledge. It is that he cannot use it in a room he cannot yet hold.

This is where two of Unit 5's findings become concrete. New teachers absorb the elastic work because they do not yet know they may decline it, and burnout risk is high at this stage for exactly that reason.

What this stage needs is a mentor, reduced load, and help with the specific thing that is actually blocking them, which is usually classroom management rather than technique. Ordinary survival help.

What is usually offered instead is the same generic in-service programme given to everyone, plus, frequently, the hardest classes, on the reasoning that senior teachers have earned the better ones.

The experienced teacher stage

The experienced teacher stage covers the long remainder, and it is the least served.

What changes is that the mechanics have become automatic. Attention is freed. A teacher at this stage can do things that were impossible earlier: notice an individual pupil mid-explanation, change course in a lesson, hold a class while thinking about something else.

The characteristic difficulty is that nothing external requires any further change. The classes run, the results hold, nobody complains. This is where Topic 6.1's drift operates, and it is slow enough to be invisible from inside.

What this stage needs is genuine challenge: someone who will observe and say something true, a problem worth solving, a role that requires learning something new, contact with practice outside the school. Mrs Aslam's nineteen years without a single honest observation is the common case, not an unlucky one.

What is usually offered instead is the same generic session for the fifth time, or an administrative promotion that removes them from teaching altogether.

A misconception belongs here: **experienced teachers have finished developing**. The stage model says the opposite. The experienced stage is the one with the most capacity for development, because attention is free, and the least external pressure toward it. Capacity and demand are inversely arranged, which is why development at this stage has to be self-driven or it does not happen.

A caution about stage models generally. These stages describe a common pattern, not a law. Teachers move at different rates, a change of school or subject can return an experienced teacher to something like the new-teacher

stage, and long service is not the same as being in the experienced stage in this sense. Use the model to locate what you need, not to categorise people.

Activity: Three teachers, one session

Work in groups of three, taking one of Sana, Imran and Mrs Aslam each.

For your teacher, write what the questioning session actually offered them, what they needed instead, and one thing the session's organiser could have done to make it useful for your teacher specifically without abandoning the other two.

Read all three out. Then answer as a group: is a single session for all three stages salvageable, or is the mixed-stage room the fundamental problem? Give reasons.

Allow 25 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name the three stages and state what changes at each transition.
(Remember)
2. Explain why the new teacher transition is more abrupt in teaching than in most professions. *(Understand)*
3. Sana and Imran both know about wait time and neither uses it. Explain why, and show that the reasons differ. *(Apply)*
4. Explain why the experienced stage has the most capacity for development and the least pressure toward it. *(Analyze)*
5. Give, for any two stages, the support that helps and the support usually offered instead. *(Remember)*
6. Why should a stage model be used to locate a need rather than to categorise a teacher? *(Understand)*

Summary

A teaching career passes through three broad stages. The preservice stage ends when responsibility transfers; its difficulty is that everything is new at once, so attention goes to mechanics, and it needs structured practice with feedback rather than more content. The new teacher stage begins with an abrupt transition to full responsibility; its difficulty is survival, and it needs a mentor, a reduced load and help with what is actually blocking the teacher, usually classroom management.

The experienced stage is the longest and least served. Mechanics have become automatic and attention is free, so capacity for development is at its highest, while external pressure toward it is at its lowest. Its difficulty is that nothing requires change, which is where drift operates. It needs genuine challenge and honest observation, and is usually offered a repeat session or an administrative promotion.

At every stage the support offered tends to mismatch the support needed. Stage models describe a common pattern rather than a law, and are for locating a need, not for categorising a person.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the three stages and what changes at each transition.
- ☐ I can state the characteristic difficulty of each stage.
- ☐ I can explain why two teachers who know the same technique may both be unable to use it.
- ☐ I can explain the inverse arrangement of capacity and pressure in the experienced stage.
- ☐ I can locate myself and a colleague on the model without treating it as a label.

Try this at your practicum school

Find a teacher at each stage in your practicum school if you can: someone in their first years and someone with long service.

Ask each the same question: "What would actually help you get better at this?"

Write half a page comparing the answers against what this topic says each stage needs. The answers are often more specific and more modest than the topic predicts, and where they differ from it, the teachers are the better evidence.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

A district has budget for one professional development intervention, for all teachers, once a year. Using the stage model, argue what it should spend it on.

Your answer must use all three stages, acknowledge that one intervention cannot serve them equally, and reach a defended choice. Address the objection that spending on new teachers abandons the experienced majority, or that spending on the experienced abandons those most at risk of leaving.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the stage model (Apply)	Applies all three stages with their specific needs, not a general plea for more training
Recognition of the constraint	Accepts that one intervention cannot serve all three, rather than proposing three
Defended choice (Evaluate)	States the criterion the choice rests on and answers the objection from the group not chosen
Realism	The proposal is deliverable once a year on a district budget

Further reading

- Day, C. (1999). *Developing teachers: The challenges of lifelong learning*. Falmer Press. On development across a working life rather than at its start.
- Villegas-Reimers, E. (2003). *Teacher professional development: An international review of the literature*. UNESCO IIEP.

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